PATIN / TERO!

Section 2 — Core Game Loop

Game Design Document • Reconstructed Section 2

This section recreates the core gameplay loop and session flow based on our previous discussions. It preserves the established mechanics and design direction, although the wording may differ from the original.

2.1 The Loop

The core gameplay loop of PATIN / TERO! revolves around strategic preparation, deterministic execution, and adaptation. Players build and improve their teams, configure their offensive and defensive formations, and program unit movements before watching their strategies unfold automatically.

Unlike traditional real-time strategy games, players do not directly control their units during battle. Instead, they make all meaningful decisions during the planning phase. Once the battle begins, runners and guards execute their assigned movement commands without player intervention.

The core gameplay loop follows seven stages:

Stage	Action	Purpose
1	SHOP	Purchase characters and improve your roster.
2	DEPLOY	Assign runners and guards to valid starting positions.
3	PROGRAM	Select and arrange signature moveset cards.
4	BATTLE	Watch both arenas execute simultaneously.
5	SCORE	Evaluate offense and defense outcomes.
6	ELIMINATION	Update standings and remove qualifying bottom-ranked players.
7	REPEAT	Use earned resources to adapt for the next round.

Stage 1 — Shop

At the beginning of each planning phase, players receive coins that can be spent on characters or shop rerolls.

The shop presents five character offers. Players can purchase characters to expand their roster, strengthen existing units through merging, or improve their team composition.

Each character belongs to a specific role and has three unique signature moveset cards. Choosing which characters to purchase is an important strategic decision because different characters provide different movement patterns and tactical possibilities.

Players must balance immediate improvements against saving resources for future rounds.

Stage 2 — Deploy

After purchasing characters, players arrange their units across two separate 4×8 arenas: an offense arena and a defense arena.

The offense arena supports up to three runners. Runners can only be deployed at designated starting positions along row 0.

The defense arena supports three horizontal guards and one center guard. Horizontal guards occupy predefined patrol lines, while the center guard moves along the center line between columns 1 and 2.

Players may reposition their units only within valid deployment points assigned to their roles. Runners cannot be placed in the defense arena, and guards cannot be placed in the offense arena.

Formation decisions determine where units begin executing their programmed movement sequences.

Stage 3 — Program Movesets

Each character has three predefined signature moveset cards. Every card contains a sequence of four movement commands.

Players select and arrange these cards to determine how each unit behaves during battle.

The number of cards a unit can equip depends on its star level:

Star level	Equipped moveset cards
★	1 card
★★	2 distinct cards
★★★	All 3 cards

When multiple cards are equipped, they execute in the selected order. After the final command, the sequence loops back to the beginning.

Players cannot modify individual commands within a card. Strategy comes from selecting characters, combining cards, arranging their execution order, and choosing starting positions.

This creates a programming-based tactical system in which players must anticipate how their units will interact with opposing movement patterns.

Stage 4 — Simultaneous Battle

Once both players lock their formations, the planning phase ends and battle begins.

Both arenas execute simultaneously:

• Offense: The player’s runners attempt to cross the opponent’s guards, reach row 7, and return safely to row 0.

• Defense: The player’s guards attempt to intercept and tag the opponent’s runners before they complete their round trips.

All units execute their movement commands automatically according to deterministic simulation rules.

Players cannot reposition units, change movesets, purchase characters, or intervene during battle.

Both arenas use the same physical 3D boards shown during planning, maintaining visual continuity between preparation and execution.

The battle continues until each arena reaches its resolution condition or its time limit expires.

Stage 5 — Score

After both arenas resolve, the game evaluates the player's offensive and defensive performance.

Each arena produces an outcome that contributes to the overall match result.

A player may win both arenas, win one arena and lose the other, or lose both arenas.

A successful offensive round trip occurs when a runner reaches the opposite end of the board and returns to its starting side without being tagged.

A defensive victory occurs when the guards successfully prevent the opposing runners from completing their objective under the applicable arena resolution rules.

The results screen communicates the outcome of each arena, tournament points earned, and any applicable economic rewards.

Stage 6 — Elimination

After scoring, the tournament standings are updated.

Players are ranked according to their accumulated tournament points and applicable tiebreaker rules.

At designated elimination checkpoints, the bottom-ranked players are removed from the tournament.

The tournament progressively reduces the number of participants until only the finalists remain.

Eliminated players no longer participate in subsequent tournament rounds, while surviving players continue developing their teams.

Stage 7 — Repeat

Surviving players return to the planning phase for the next round.

They receive their applicable income and can use their resources to purchase additional characters, merge matching units, adjust formations, and change equipped moveset combinations.

Players can also review previous battles and publicly available opponent information to improve their strategies.

The loop continues until the tournament reaches its final championship match and a winner is declared.

2.2 Session Flow

A complete game session consists of a tournament in which eight players compete through multiple rounds of planning and automatic battles.

The tournament follows a survival-based progression structure, gradually eliminating lower-ranked players until one champion remains.

2.2.1 Tournament Entry

The session begins when a player enters the tournament lobby.

The lobby displays the participating players, tournament format, and readiness status.

Once all required player slots are filled or the configured start conditions are satisfied, the tournament begins.

Players enter the first planning phase with their initial roster and starting resources.

2.2.2 Planning Phase

Each active player receives an opportunity to prepare their team before the next battle.

During this phase, players can purchase characters, reroll the shop, manage their bench, merge identical units, deploy characters, and configure movesets.

Players interact directly with the two 3D arenas using mouse-based drag-and-drop controls.

The shop is accessed through a modal window that can be opened and closed without leaving the planning screen.

When ready, players lock their formations. Their final unit positions, star levels, and moveset configurations are submitted for the upcoming match.

2.2.3 Match Pairing

The tournament system determines each player’s opponent for the current round.

Each match consists of two simultaneous arena simulations.

The player’s offensive formation competes against the opponent’s defensive formation, while the player’s defensive formation competes against the opponent’s offensive formation.

This means each player must prepare both an effective attack and an effective defense.

2.2.4 Battle Execution

When both matched players are ready, the battle begins automatically.

The simulation processes unit movement, command timing, collisions, tagging, and scoring using deterministic rules.

No additional player input is required during execution.

The two arenas progress independently and may finish at different times.

A match is complete only after both arenas have resolved.

2.2.5 Results and Rewards

Following the battle, the game displays the results of both arenas and calculates the match outcome.

Tournament points are awarded according to the scoring rules.

Players also receive applicable economic rewards, which can be used during subsequent planning phases.

The results screen allows players to review their performance and understand how their strategies succeeded or failed.

2.2.6 Standings and Elimination

After all matches in the current tournament round are complete, the standings are updated.

At designated checkpoints, the lowest-ranked players are eliminated.

The tournament progression follows:

Stage	Remaining players
Tournament begins	8
First elimination	6
Second elimination	4
Finalists	2
Champion	1

Elimination progression is fixed; the precise round numbers at which checkpoints occur should follow the tournament rules section.

2.2.7 Championship Match

When only two players remain, the tournament enters its championship stage.

The finalists compete under the established match rules, with any special championship restrictions applied as defined by the tournament system.

Players must rely on their accumulated roster strength, strategic preparation, and knowledge of their opponent.

The championship concludes when a winner is determined according to the final match and tiebreaker rules.

2.2.8 Session Completion

The tournament ends when one player is declared champion.

The final screen displays the champion, final standings, and relevant performance statistics.

Players may review their results before returning to the main menu or beginning another tournament.

2.3 Core Loop Design Goals

The core gameplay loop is designed around five objectives:

Meaningful preparation: Every purchase, deployment, and card-order decision should influence battle behavior.

Deterministic execution: Identical initial conditions and programmed commands should produce identical results.

Clear cause and effect: Players should understand why their units succeeded or failed.

Strategic adaptation: Each round should provide opportunities to improve formations and respond to opponents.

Short, repeatable competition: Individual battles should be concise, while tournament progression provides longer-term strategic depth.

The central player experience is:

Plan → Program → Watch → Analyze → Adapt.

Players are rewarded not for reacting faster during battle, but for creating better strategies before it begins.

Reconstruction note: This is a newly recreated Section 2 based on our established discussions, not an exact recovery of the original text. Exact tournament checkpoint timing, scoring values, and certain battle resolution details should be checked against the finalized Sections 6–7 before implementation.